

Empire-seam knit mini dress

EU38 sewing guide . 6 pieces . 2 m fabric at 140 cm

text-first guide, no illustrations in this edition. Every step is the engine's own instruction.

Cut list

Bodice Front - cut 1 on fold

Bodice Back - cut 2

Skirt Front - cut 1 on fold

Skirt Back - cut 2 (center back seam)

Sleeve - cut 2

Strips / notions (chalked on fabric, not printed)

Bias binding (neckline) - cut 1 strip(s) 511 x 25 mm ON THE BIAS (45° to the grain), join end to end (total 511 mm = edge 491 mm)

Steps

1. Print and check the 3 cm calibration square before cutting.
2. This block uses standard assumptions for shoulder slope, underbust and arm width . sew a quick muslin (test version) from cheap fabric first and adjust before cutting your real fabric.
3. Knit fabric: sew with a narrow zigzag or stretch stitch and a ballpoint/stretch needle so the seams stretch with the fabric.
4. Cut every piece as labelled: pieces marked 'on fold' on the fabric fold, 'cut 2' twice, sleeves twice.
5. Staystitch the neckline just inside the seam line so it doesn't stretch while you work.
6. Sew all darts first, pressing toward the center.
7. Sew the bodice shoulder seams and press them open.
8. Prepare the neckline bias strip: join the ends as needed and press it in half lengthwise along the marked fold line.
9. Bind the neckline with the bias strip, right sides together and raw edges even, leaving the last 2 cm free at each center back edge (the zipper goes there later). Ease the strip gently around the curves. Trim to 6 mm, turn the folded edge to the inside and topstitch or slipstitch it down.
10. Sew the bodice side seams.
11. Sew the skirt seams (leave the center back seam open where the zipper will go), then join bodice to skirt at the underbust seam (the empire line sits right under the bust), matching side seams.
12. Insert an invisible zipper in the center back through bodice and skirt: install the zipper BEFORE closing the seam below it, then close the rest of the seam. (Very stretchy knit? Baste the back seam closed first and test pulling the dress on . you may be able to skip the zipper and just sew the seam.)

13. Fold the free binding ends back over the zipper tape and hand-tack them down so the edge sits clean against the zipper.
14. Sew each sleeve seam. Run gathering stitches between the cap notches, ease the cap into the armhole and set the sleeves in.
15. Try it on, then hem with a 2 cm double fold.